and his efforts to weave a larger image of a deprived 'bahujan'. His advocacy for a caste census and for reservation policies based on updated census data has been instrumental in this shift. Given all statistical indications that OBCs form the largest segment of India's population, Rahul's emphasis on their representation serves as a strategic political tool to expand the Congress's acceptance among this crucial voter base.

Despite the Congress's centrality in Opposition politics, voter satisfaction with the party and its leadership has shown a declining trend. Only 49 per cent of the respondents rate Rahul's performance as Leader of the Opposition as good or outstanding, down from 51 per cent six months ago. The Congress's overall performance has also taken a blow, with 34 per cent of the respondents rating it as poor or very poor—a noticeable increase from 28 per cent six months ago. Simultaneously, the share of the respondents who rate the Congress's performance as outstanding or good has dropped from 44 per cent to 40 per cent.

However, though Rahul at 54 is not exactly a youth leader, he appears to be gaining traction among first-time voters. Among the respondents aged 18-24, a goodly 35 per cent rate his performance as outstanding—the highest approval rating across all age groups. This indicates that while Rahul struggles to win endorsement for his leadership among traditional voter bases, he may be finding favour with young voters seeking a fresh political narrative.

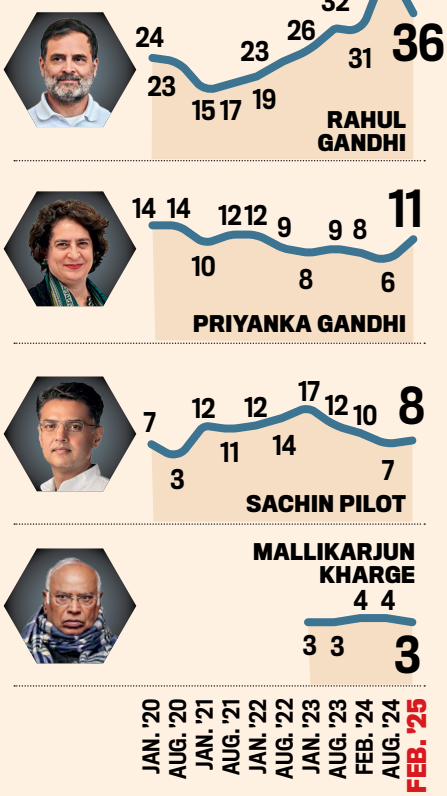
The core challenge facing the Congress is its inability to translate voter recognition into electoral success—though the party raised its tally to 99 seats in the Lok Sabha, its highest in a decade. Moreover, its setbacks in state elections, particularly in Haryana and Maharashtra, indicate that it has yet to capitalise fully on anti-incumbency sentiments. Political analysts attribute these failures to a combination of complacency, weak organisational structure and uninspiring leadership. The MOTN poll suggests that if elections were held today, the Congress's Lok Sabha tally would drop to 78—a grim forecast that underlines the party's desperate struggle to be a national alternative.

Rahul's standing within the Opposition has also weakened. When asked who is best suited to lead the INDIA bloc, only 24 per cent of the respondents backed him—a sharp decline from 32 per cent six months ago. Although he remains the top choice, the gap between him and his closest challenger, Mamata, has narrowed significantly. She now enjoys the support of 14 per cent of the respondents, double of what it was six months ago. This growing chorus among INDIA allies demanding a non-Congress leadership structure should be a cause for concern for Rahul.

Even within his own party, Rahul's dominance is waning, as per the MOTN poll. While he remains the Congress's strongest leader with 36 per cent backing him as the best person to lead the party, this is a significant drop from the 49 per cent who supported him in August 2024. Meanwhile, Priyanka Gandhi's entry into electoral politics has led to a surge in her popularity, with 11 per cent of the respondents favouring her as the ideal Congress leader—nearly double her rating six months ago. Beyond the Gandhi family, Sachin Pilot continues to hold his position as the third-most preferred leader within the Congress. It suggests that the Congress must look beyond dynastic politics and actively develop a strong bench of leaders capable of reinvigorating the party's prospects.

Voters have signalled a strong desire for a credible alternative political platform to strengthen Indian democracy, but persistent infighting and strategic missteps risk squandering this opportunity. ■

Q. Which Congress leader is best suited to lead the party?



Q. How would you rate the performance of the Congress as an Opposition party?



All figures in % and rounded off